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Jerry Dodgion

Jerry Dodgion has been a member of some of our finest big bands. He was born in Richmond, California in 1932 and took up the alto saxophone in junior high school. His first professional engagements came in his early twenties with Benny Carter, Gerald Wilson and Red Norvo. In the late 50s he toured Europe and Australia, first with Frank Sinatra and later with Benny Goodman. Jerry later became part of the New York jazz scene, often performing with his wife, jazz drummer Dottie Dodgion. He has worked with Marian McPartland and Vince Guaraldi and was a founding member of the famed Thad Jones-Mel Lewis Orchestra.

Jerry was interviewed by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, in New York City on March 9, 1996.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and it's my great pleasure to have with me saxophonist and reed man Jerry Dodgion. Welcome.

JD: Thank you very much. Nice to be here.

MR: I wonder, you are a Californian originally, right?

JD: Sure.

MR: I wonder if during these winters here if you ever wish you still were?

JD: Well I've been here a little while. I guess I came in 1961, I thought maybe we'd stay about five years. So I think the five years isn't up yet. This is '96. It took 35 years.

MR: You found work here then, to keep you here.

JD: Yeah, well sure. I think New York's the greatest place in the world if you have a good reason to be here. It's wonderful.

MR: Can you tell me, what was pop music, what was the pop music of the time when you were first starting on your instrument, and did it influence where you went as a musician at all?

JD: Gee, I don't know. Pop music, like I remember it was just radio, you know just bands and singers and that was in the late 40s and early 50s. But when I got interested in it there was in school, and I just got lucky. I started working with professional musicians when I was in high school and I worked with some local bands around San Francisco that were great and very encouraging. The pop music, I didn't find out until — I just really wasn't too interested in the real, hard core pop, I mean that was like—

MR: It was the era of, I guess the big band era had kind of ended.

JD: Oh it was over actually but I mean there was still remnants of stuff happening. And then there were a lot of records being made with bands with singers, with the singers featured instead of the band being featured. So as a matter of fact, when I eventually moved to

New York, I'd been playing with Red Norvo for three years, with the quintet. And we played all over. We played in Las Vegas a lot. We played for Frank Sinatra for his personal appearances for about a year and a half, and we played with Benny Goodman several times during that time, our first time to Europe. And everything, it was really like a great experience for me. Then when I did stay in New York, the work that I started to do mainly through — I knew Jerome Richardson from San Francisco and we had played together in Gerald Wilson's band there. And so when I came to New York he encouraged me to come and everything and he helped me a great deal. And on my first recording date when I was here he called me because he was contracting for Quincy Jones. And my very first record date was with Quincy Jones and Dinah Washington. That was, like it was wonderful. So somebody said, "How do you like New York so far?" On my first date it was good. Wonderful.

MR: That's wonderful. So much of the music business is getting work through friends and establishing contacts.

JD: Sure. In those days the pop music was still jazz oriented more so. Then later on it became more rock & roll, even eighth note oriented. So it changes, it's changing all the time.

MR: Can I just back up? You just said "even note oriented."

JD: Even eighth note.

MR: Yes. See I never heard anybody quite describe — we know how swing eighth notes go and how rock & roll eighth notes go, but no one ever exactly said the music became even note oriented. That's very interesting to me.

JD: Well some drummers, if you talk to some drummers, they might tell you that. Because that's a basic thing. It's an even eighth note as opposed to the twelve eight, smooth flowing.

MR: New York had a very active recording scene at that time.

JD: Oh, yeah.

MR: And were you working with your wife at that time?

JD: We did do some work together. She played with us, Dottie played with us with Benny Goodman for two weeks at the Basin Street East. And then later on she played with Marian McPartland, I used to go and sit in with them sometimes. And occasionally we worked some quartet gigs here and there you know.

MR: Well you mentioned some pretty big names in the business: Sinatra and Benny Goodman. What was it like to work with those gentlemen?

JD: For me it was great. I mean it was all first time experience and I was just, I loved it. Every minute it was something new happening all the time. Learning something about this and learning about that, and working with really great musicians that were really

great human beings. So it was just a constant role of learning and having fun at the same time, all mixed up together. It was really great.

MR: Were you required to play all the woodwinds at that time? The flute and clarinet?

JD: Well with Red I played just alto and flute. I didn't play any clarinet with him but I'd been playing the clarinet for years, you know, since one of my first teachers. But I'm still not really a multi-reed — I don't consider myself a multi-reed specialist. I play the alto sax, the soprano sax, the clarinet and the flute. That's about it.

MR: Stay away from those double reeds. They can be —

JD: Oh, yeah. I have enough trouble with the single reeds.

MR: They're nasty, oh my. Well you've been with some of the great big bands, from Gerald Wilson through Benny Carter. Tell me how the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band kind of gelled into a great organization.

JD: Gee. I knew Thad, I had met him in San Francisco when he was with Count Basie, and we played together at an after hours place there. And I met Mel through playing with Peggy Lee in New York and then eventually with Benny Goodman. We went to Russia and Mel was the drummer with Benny Goodman. And I knew both of these guys separately. I didn't know them together. And then Mel called one day and said, "Oh, Thad Jones and I are starting a band and we would like you to play in the band. Would you be interested?" I said, "I wouldn't miss it for anything." I knew them separately and I thought this is the odd couple of all times, this maybe will be one rehearsal. It'll be terrific. It's got to be wonderful. And so who knows? And it turned out to be a magnificent marriage of two different individuals. It was a great experience. It was the best musical experience I could ever imagine myself in. It was too late for me to play with Duke Ellington, and so it was something new that was really great and I loved it, I really loved it. I learned a lot. And Thad was, besides the most fantastic musician in his soloing, I mean he soloed like nobody. He didn't sound like anybody else. He was a total individual. He was a beautiful soloist and that's who I'd heard play with Count Basie. I heard the band many times. And then to find out he could write — I knew he could write beautifully because I heard some of the Count Basie arrangements he did. And then his writing was unbelievable. But many people don't know that didn't see the band, don't know what a great conductor he was. A fantastic conductor, but he was in total control of the band, the rhythmic pulse, everything. It was just wonderful.

MR: I wish I could have seen something at the Vanguard, just to see the band fit in there first of all. It must have been a little crowded.

JD: Well we sat very close together and it was very funny that the first time we played out of the Vanguard we had one concert in someplace in Long Island at a college, I can't remember which, and Monk had just played, Jackie McLean was playing with Monk and

then we went on, and we were not sitting close together. And after the first — we played the first tune and Bob Brookmeyer sitting behind me I hear him say, "I told you you guys couldn't play outside of the Vanguard. It sounds terrible." So we had everybody sit closer together. So we sat closer together like we did at the Vanguard and then the band started to sound better again. It was really funny. It was great.

MR: I want to read something that was written about you in the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz*. See if you think that this guy knows what he's talking about. He says: "Dodgion's saxophone playing, influenced by that of Charlie Parker, Art Pepper and Jerome Richardson, is well represented by his inventive solo on 'Tip Toe,' which draws on blues formulas and demonstrates a relaxed rhythmic sense and the ability to develop motifs."

JD: Gee that's pretty formal I guess.

MR: Did you know you were a motif developer?

JD: I never thought of it that way but it's complimentary.

MR: Yes, it is nice. When you play do you think about developing little lines and so forth or it just comes?

JD: That's hard you know because I never did really study how to play jazz. Like they have colleges that you can go to now and you can major in jazz. You can learn in three weeks now what took me fifteen years to learn. But I know it's information-wise, you know? So it's really hard, and I'm not a teacher either, I don't do any teaching. So it's hard for me to tell somebody how I feel about what I'm doing, it really is. So maybe if I were better at that I would have been a teacher. I don't know.

MR: Yeah. Well sometimes your own style is the hardest to talk about. I know I read about one fellow who did a very extensive study on Sonny Rollins and how he apparently developed all these motifs and after Sonny Rollins read it then he felt he couldn't do it anymore, because now he was thinking too hard about it. Where before it was just a natural thing. Now that someone tells him what he's doing, it's hard to do now.

JD: That's possible. Because when you're doing it, or when I'm doing it anyway, I'm not thinking of how I'm doing it. You just try to play your best and to fit in with what's happening around you. That's the main thing for me. I mean if I play with sensitive players it's very easy to play and you don't get tired, you have a lot of fun. And if you play with people that aren't sensitive, that aren't listening to each other and stuff, pretty soon you find, I'm really getting tired and the music is not fun, what am I doing here? I mean without getting too analytical about it, if it's not fun and it's not happening, you know it's not happening. And just to keep playing and to try to make it happen is futile sometimes. Because when it's really happening it's not because you're making it happen I don't think. I think when it really happens is when you're letting it happen. And that's the best stuff.

MR: That's putting it pretty well. How did the couple, you played on this particular record with Basie.

JD: Oh, that one.

MR: Yeah. Remember that one?

JD: Sure I do.

MR: Nice record. And how did that come about?

JD: Well I knew almost everybody in the band because I'd gone to hear the band so much in those years. And one day Billy Mitchell called me and he said, "What are you doing Thursday?" I said, "I'm not doing anything, why?" He said, "Well would you like to make a recording date with Count Basie?" I said, "That's why I'm alive." I mean that's the dream, I mean unbelievable, I thought that's never going to happen. Well he said Bobby Plater had to take off, because he was writing a date for Lockjaw that was scheduled at the exact same time so he couldn't be there, so would I come in and play. I said great. So I got to play with Marshall Royal, with Basie, and that was always a dream too, you know, because the consummate lead alto player for that band. As Thad used to say, "tailor made lead alto." That was really a thrill. Wonderful.

MR: Did they spend a lot of time in those sessions or was it pretty much a couple of takes?

JD: These arrangements were by Chico O'Farrill, who was really great writer and people don't realize how great he is and how he can handle a variety of situations, he's really very musical. Well the band had been playing together, the band was on the road, they'd been playing you know, and to put a new arrangement in front of them, it didn't take very long at all. I mean they read very well. That particular band was very versatile. They played for singers. Sometimes they played for Frank Sinatra, they played for Tony Bennett or somebody, and they could make a rehearsal and learn the music in a couple of hours. And it was very professional. Just to sit in there and sit next to Marshall and hear all the saxes, in those days they recorded with the saxes sitting around in a circle around the microphone. I don't know why they gave that up. But it's really great because you balance yourself, the sound balance. You hear everybody. You can hear everybody in the section. Now when they put you in a straight line, the people at each end don't hear equally. So the leader has to say, "Oh you're too loud" and, "you're too soft." And so when you're sitting in a circle of saxophones you can really get inside as a unit.

MR: Who was playing drums on that?

JD: Ed Shaughnessy played drums on that.

MR: Yeah, that's right.

JD: And he did great. He was added for that date and Sweets was on the band too, Harry Edison was on the band. That was the first time, well not the first time I've played in a recording with him, but he soloed and everything. It was great.

MR: Yeah, the arrangements did a good job of — the theme was Broadway tunes or whatever and to fit them in the Basie style.

JD: Well this was the Hollywood one.

MR: Hollywood. That's right.

JD: With the movie themes and the like.

MR: That's great. Did you get a chance again to record with them?

JD: Yes, several years later. I didn't even know it was with Count Basie which was good because I would have probably been nervous. I got a call for three days of recording with Chico O'Farrill on the answering service. And I showed up and it was Count Basie's band. I'm looking around and I said am I in the right studio? So then I see Chico and I says I guess so. I mean that was really great. That was a lot of fun too. That was an album called "Basic Basie." And I even played a few solos on that, which I was a little apprehensive about. I mean Lockjaw was on that too and he made that great recording of "Bewitched" on one of those dates. It was really wonderful to see this and be in there and be part of it happening. Because I loved the music so much and heard it on records so much, and heard the band in person. I heard the band in person a lot. And that band, the band of the 50s and 60s was an unbelievable ensemble band. Maybe it was really one of the best ever. They could play with the great swinging and feeling and the emotion and everything. But together. And the ensemble was just so together it was just thrilling. And the dynamics, unbelievable. I mean they could play softer than we're talking now, the whole band. And you'd still hear the bass with no amplifier. Frank Wess would play the flute, Thad did some things with flute and bass, and you could hear him. Now I don't know — when the amplification came in it changed everything, you know? The bass became louder than the band and you could not hear the flute unless you turned up the mic and when the flute player turns up his mic then the bass player turns up his mic and then there's the guitar player, forget it. And here were — and there's no end to this stuff. But the real sensitive part of playing acoustically, that band just was the best ever. I just, I couldn't believe it.

MR: Fantastic.

JD: It was a great experience trying to play in that context.

MR: Who were the fellas — according to our dictionary here, you were influenced by Charlie Parker. Is that a fair statement?

JD: Well sure.

MR: Wasn't everybody I guess.

JD: I guess, sure. I mean I was never good enough to copy anybody so I just probably — in the words of Pepper Adams, one time we were doing a clinic with the Thad Jones saxophone section. We had about 200 saxophone players in the room. So I said, "We

can't give you a saxophone lesson in an hour and a half, but if you ask some questions, you'll get five different answers from professionals and that will maybe give you a real idea of what your answer is and whether it's career minded or whatever it is, music or whatever." So somebody asked the question, "Who do you copy when you're learning to improvise?" And I think Billy Harper says, "Well I don't copy anybody you know. I got my own stuff" you know and everything. And then Ed Higgins says, "Well you know I listen to Charlie Parker and Lester Young" and so-and-so and so-and-so. And I said basically the same thing. I listen to records. I heard Lester Young, Charlie Parker, and Johnny Hodges, you name it. And then Ron Bridgewater said something, I don't remember what he said, but when Pepper spoke he says, "Well you know" he says, "when you copy from one person" he says, "that's plagiarism. But if you copy from everybody it's called research." And so we just fell out. I said, "Why didn't he speak first so we wouldn't have to make a fool of ourselves." You know the question is so — you say one word and it takes you five minutes to cover up what you just said in your own answer. It's out.

MR: It's an excellent answer. Clark Terry, he has the "ations." He says first there's imitation, and then I think he said assimilation, and then creation of your own thing.

JD: Well he's one of the masters of all time. He's just magnificent. I've had a chance to play with him a few times, it was just unbelievable, just wonderful. Enjoyment, fun, and a music lesson too. It's just everything, just everything.

MR: So you mentioned having a service and they would call you. A typical week for a New York musician could involve a lot of different kind of work is that right?

JD: Oh, yeah, sure.

MR: And what were some of the things that maybe weren't as exciting as performing with Count Basie that you do on a day-to-day basis to allow you to live in New York?

JD: Well, jeez, that's hard to say, to put that together. I could tell you a story about when I first moved here, I called Jerome Richardson, because he'd encouraged me to come, and he said, you know he was really encouraging, leaning on me really. And I'd met Oliver Nelson when were playing with Frank Sinatra with Red Norvo. I'd met him in Atlantic City. He was playing with Wild Bill Davis. Later he was playing with Basie for a short while when we were in Las Vegas. So Oliver said, "When you come to New York call me." So I just called those two guys, and ended up on Quincy Jones recording dates and Oliver Nelson recording dates, and I see Urbie Green on these dates. And Urbie I'd met from playing with Benny Goodman and with Red Norvo. And Urbie says, "Jerry, I see you're on all the best dates." I says, "What do you mean, aren't they all like this?" See all I was doing, I wasn't doing a lot of work, but the work was of great caliber, it was just wonderful. He said, "No, no, they're not all like this." Well other stuff, in those days a lot

of it was pretty interesting because there were a lot of big bands playing for singers. Even the pop music of the day, I mean we did dates with Quincy for Sarah Vaughan. And it was just a lot of fun. And the beauty and the exchange between the musicians and the fraternity of musicians was really great. It was just wonderful. I always felt that I was welcomed for whatever I could contribute, and I got the chance to learn from it. I've just never been able to reciprocate, you know, I have not. When young musicians come now I can't, there's not that kind of work around. I can't steer them into anything. It's a different time. Just like that was a different time than what preceded it.

MR: I wanted to mention this one record here that was done with Thad and Joe.

JD: Oh.

MR: Remember that one? I think you played on that one too.

JD: Oh, with Joe Williams. Oh, now he's another special case. Oh, man. We met when I was with Red Norvo we played Las Vegas a lot, and when the band started coming to the Flamingo there, they'd come in for three or four weeks at a time sometimes. And so we met Joe, and he's a really beautiful person, and he was part of the band. He was not a star with the band. I mean they traveled together these guys, and they roomed together, and he was just like one of the guys in the band. You know, there was a humanity thing happening with the Basie band that was just wonderful. It was just a joy to watch, and to be able to touch it a little bit was great for me. On this particular date, you know when we made this it was so funny with Thad and Mel's band whenever — we didn't rehearse very much. And in some of the chronicles they say it was a rehearsal band and then it became a band. It was never a rehearsal band, and Thad and Mel hated the word "rehearsal band." They started the band to have a band. And when people say, "This is a rehearsal band," they hated it. It's not true. I mean Duke Pearson's band rehearsed every week for a year and they never called him a "rehearsal band." Thad and Mel had two rehearsals and went into the Vanguard and they called it a "rehearsal band." I mean that was a very unfair — I mean it was no big deal to me, but to them it was really, you know?

MR: I guess they just meant that the band didn't tour around the country. I mean gee a gig at the Vanguard is hardly a rehearsal.

JD: But anyway, when we did rehearse, we'd have to rehearse like at midnight or something, because a lot of a guys had studio work in the day. Not me so much, I was never really a full time studio player. And there was a lot of work. A lot of guys were full time studio — but there was so much work that there was overflow work all the time, so then you got called by people you didn't know lots of times because of recommendations, just to go in and deal with whatever you had to do. Very challenging stuff sometimes you know. Playing the saxophone is one thing and when you play the flute, it can be you think oh I

can handle this, and you turn the page and all of a sudden you're in another world. Maybe you're playing alone with a harp or something, you know it's very sensitive stuff. You've just been playing in a circus on the page before, who knows? But getting back to this, this was really exceptional. I remember this so well because in order to get the band and Joe together the scheduling was ridiculous. It started at eight in the morning on a couple of the days and one was at seven in the morning. Now this is, for the band that's unusual. Dates usually start at ten. So eight's okay, but seven, unheard of. But Joe Williams, during that week was working at the Half Note, and I went down to hear him. I mean they finished at the Half Note at quarter to four in the morning. Then he was singing every night 'til a quarter of four, and then he would make this, start coming in for one of these records at seven o'clock. So there was no sleep for him. I mean and he just did great. And if you hear this record you'd have no idea that he was up all night to do this. I mean that's just unbelievable.

MR: I was going to think if he had just gotten out of bed for that you wouldn't be able to hear his voice, 'cause it'd be so low.

JD: Yeah. So to take a nap would be ridiculous. But you know there is something about when everything is going right and it's for a really good — you just pull up everything you have to do it. You know and it just happens. Sometimes when you're a little exhausted you don't have time to get nervous, you just save all the energy for what it's meant for and it works that way sometimes.

MR: Very interesting.

JD: But just try to do it on purpose and see what happens. I'll never forget that though. That's wonderful. I'm glad that that's out on CD now.

MR: Yeah. And it sounds great. Quite a band there too.

JD: Oh, yeah.

MR: And eventually you stepped into Jerome's spot, the lead player, right?

JD: Yeah well he left to go to California in '72 I guess.

MR: What about, you've been around the world a little bit with some different groups. Do you enjoy traveling like that?

JD: Oh, yeah. I was really fortunate to do some traveling. I know that I could have never done it on my own, to see the variety of stuff and see how people live and how music is different in different places, and the food, and everything is, traveling is one of the greatest things you can do if you do it under good conditions you know. I think my first time was with Benny Goodman in Russia, I mean not in Russia but in Europe in 1959. It was with the small band. He hired Red Norvo's quintet, which is pianoless, and added Jack Sheldon and Bill Harris and Flip Phillips. And he had arrangements written for the

four horns, which made it a ten piece band. And we toured Europe and had a great time. I see more and more stories coming in, as we're slowing down the interview here.

MR: That's okay. We like stories.

JD: All the Benny Goodman stories are true you know. That tells a lot right there. And I just learned a lot with Flip Phillips, what a wonderful musician he is. And he is to this day. He's 80 now and he still plays wonderfully, amazing, just great. And he was such a moving spirit in this band. I mean he always had a great sense of humor. And of course Bill Harris has a sense of humor. And we did a lot of laughing. It was great. Whenever Benny would start to get a little tense and you'd think what's going to happen now, Flip would call Benny aside and say, "Benny I'd like to talk to you for a minute." And he'd talk to him for a minute, and get him laughing, and come back and we'd be okay for about three days. He'd be laughing and having really fun. The music was better and everything's better. And then Benny would start to get — Flip would say, "Come here." He'd talk to him about, he'd talk to him. I remember hearing him talk to him once he said to Benny he says, "You know Pops, you don't have to make a name for yourself, you're already the King of Swing. And you know you should be having a good time playing music, like we are." He said, "You don't pay us enough that we should get nervous here." And it was just great. And then pretty soon he ended up by telling him, "Now you have to remember this: remember I-W-S." And Benny says, "I-W-S? What's that?" He says, "I won't snap." And oh, and just everybody would laugh and so that was the slogan of the tour: I-W-S. And without Flip it could have been very, you know, a lot different. It was just great in every way. Musically he played great all the time, every time.

MR: Well that's great. We hope to see Flip in April in Florida.

JD: Oh great. I think his birthday's in April.

MR: Speaking about — they called him Pops? Benny was "Pops" is that right?

JD: Well Flip called him Pops because he called everybody else Pops. And you know it's like Louis Armstrong called people Pops but he was Pops. But when he'd talk to you he'd say, "Hey Pops you want to do this?"

MR: And Lionel Hampton calls everybody "Gates."

JD: Yeah, well he says that. Yeah, that's right.

MR: Now you were "the Deacon" is that right?

JD: Well that's one of the — Thad had little names for people now and then. He called me "Deacon Dodgion" a few times.

MR: Deacon Dodgion. All right. Was there a reason for that?

JD: Oh I don't know.

MR: Sounded good.

JD: Maybe just phonetically it was good. I don't think there was any deep spiritual attachment. But Thad was marvelous. He just brought the best out of everyone. I mean anyone who came into the band to play, even just for a few days or a day, they would walk away with, "How did I do that? I can't do that, I can't play that." Because he would do that. He just brought the best out of everyone. I mean the humanity level was great. The music was great. It was just the greatest experience imaginable. So when I started doing dates with, you know you'd do an orchestra date or something, the guy next to you went to Juilliard and he's talking about Juilliard. And the guy on this side, he went to Curtis you know, and they're talking about their conservatories and they look at me like I'm supposed to say something. So I say, "Well I went to the Vanguard Conservatory," I says, "I'm still there." I said, "At this time I was at the Conservatory for twelve years." And they look very, you know, quizzical looks. Never heard of that one you know. It was a lot of fun though.

MR: No better experience than that.

JD: Oh, unbelievable.

MR: And what's your weeks like these days? Playing different kinds of things now?

JD: Well I still have — a variety of stuff happens, it's wonderful. I play in the Carnegie Hall band that Jon Faddis leads, and we do four concerts a year in Carnegie Hall and then we've been getting some more outside work. We went to Japan year before last for a week to a festival. And we went to South America this past November for ten days and we're going to Mexico City in a couple of weeks. And we do some of the festivals in Europe in the summer, the well traveled path. And more and more stuff is coming up. And every concert is different because there's new music written for each concert. It's really interesting. It really keeps you on your toes. And Jon is developing into an excellent band leader now. His experience with Thad helped him quite a bit. So maybe if you get a chance you might—

MR: Talk to him, yeah. Who else is playing in that group?

JD: Well in the saxophones there's Frank Wess and Dick Oatts, Ralph LaLama, Gary Smulyan. Slide Hampton's in the band and he writes for the band too which is —

MR: We know that. We heard that the other night.

JD: Oh yes, well you know he's been a good writer for a long time and he's just wonderful. He's still growing. It's wonderful. It's great. The trumpet section of that band is always great because they have Lew Soloff and Earl Gardner and Byron Stripling and Randy Brecker. If you want to have a successful — I always tell the arrangers if you want a successful arrangement with this band just write the trumpets in unison and it's going to sound like no other band in the world. And then with Jon too then you have five. Oh it's

unbelievable. So he gets the best guys that are available to play in the band, which is really good.

MR: You mentioned Frank Wess and he had a pretty important role in the Basie band during his tenure didn't he?

JD: Oh, sure. I think he was responsible for a lot of people being there. I know he got Thad in the band, and maybe Snooky. I mean these are some of the most important people in the band and of course he played the flute. And this was totally unique in the whole Basie tradition. And the sound that he brought, his contribution. And he's also another great arranger. I mean not just a good arranger, he's a great arranger. And Frank Foster. I mean you ask Frank Foster who the best arranger in the band was, he always says Frank Wess. And it was great, it was great. Just wonderful. And they all wrote just beautifully. They're still playing some of Frank's compositions with the band.

MR: There is one particular album I remember that they did with Frank Sinatra where Frank's flute was so wonderful. He just played behind and added that great touch.

JD: Well he does everything great. He plays alto great. He plays tenor great. He plays flute. I mean he's just another special case. He calls me his "pastor." So I called him my "musical director." It's just a — you know to be able to play with real people and play music and to try to do your best, it's the greatest experience in the world. It's a great opportunity. Every once in a while I get these opportunities you know, and I don't underestimate the richness of the whole thing, I really don't. For me it's just so rewarding, every time.

MR: Great. Well that sounds like a good note to wrap this up on. I really enjoyed talking to you, and hope that your upcoming tours go as exciting as the Benny Goodman one was in Europe.

JD: Oh they're all different, they're all special and they're all brand new things. It's wonderful. It's great.

MR: It's exciting to come down to New York and feel the atmosphere. I know times change, but it's still great to see what's going on in the clubs. I guess it must be hard to keep a big band together like the one we saw. They don't tour all that much, do they?

JD: Well not any band tours a lot now except the Basie band I guess is the only really working band. But there are bands in New York now. Last I counted there were about 24, which a few years back they were on one hand. But Maria Schneider's band is an excellent band. She's kept that together. And the Vanguard band is excellent, I mean it's still a wonderful band. And there's just a lot of bands.

MR: Yeah. You've got an awful lot of good people to choose from to help them keep going. Yeah.

JD: Yeah.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton College I'd like to thank you for your time today.

JD: Thank you.

MR: It's been fascinating.

JD: Thank you. It was fun being here.

MR: All right.

JD: Sorry I couldn't think of anything to say.